

AI TOOLS THAT WORK

Ask Better

The same request asked two ways: short, then specific. Three tests, with the real answers.

Tested October 4, 2026

Why this guide

You type a short request into an AI chat and get a long answer that is not quite what you wanted. Is the tool bad? Not really. A short ask leaves everything open, so the tool guesses.

Here I asked three things twice. First short. Then with the facts, the limits and the format. Then I checked what changed.

Four things made the difference:

1. **Facts.** What is true, in your words.
2. **Limits.** Length, tone, what not to say.
3. **Format.** A note, a list, 5 sentences.
4. **Placeholders.** Names and details you fill in yourself.

The situations are made up. The prompts and the answers are real.

How I tested

I used a free public chat demo, with no account and no payment: the Qwen3 demo on Hugging Face

(huggingface.co/spaces/Qwen/Qwen3-Demo), model shown as Qwen3-235B-A22B.

I ran six chats on October 4, 2026, from about 4:23 to 4:26 AM Saudi time, each in a new chat: three short asks and three specific asks. One run each, so another run can answer differently.

The demo garbles dollar signs, so money is written as "600 dollars" in the prompts. Answer 3A still shows a few raw dollar signs.

Keep it private. This is a public demo. Do not paste real names, addresses or account numbers. That is why my prompts use placeholders.

EXAMPLE 1

A note to a neighbor

The neighbor's dog barks late at night. You want to keep things friendly.

The point: tell it what is true and what to leave out. With a short ask, it makes up the details.

VERSION A: THE SHORT ASK

Write a note to my neighbor about noise.

VERSION B: THE SPECIFIC ASK

Write a note to my neighbor. Facts: their dog barks most evenings after 10 pm. I like them and want to keep things friendly. I want to ask if we can talk about it. Do not mention the landlord or any rules. Under 60 words. Plain text. Leave [NEIGHBOR] and [MY NAME] as placeholders.

Version A: what it wrote

EXCERPT OF THE ANSWER, 20.7 SECONDS

Only parts of the answer are shown here, with [...] where I skipped text. The full answer is in the appendix at the end.

Dear Neighbor,

[...]

There have been a few recent occasions—especially late in the evening or early in the morning—when the noise level (music, TV, or conversations) seemed a bit louder than usual.

[...]

P.S. Sorry for any awkwardness—I hate to bring it up, but I truly appreciate your thoughtfulness!

[...]

This note balances politeness with clarity, frames the request as a collaborative effort, and avoids blame to maintain a positive relationship. Adjust details as needed! [star emoji]

What needed fixing

- It was never told about a dog. It guessed "music, TV, or conversations" and "early morning". I said neither.
- It runs about 240 words, with a P.S. and an emoji. A neighbor would find it heavy.
- It apologizes twice and ends with "looking forward to continuing to be friendly neighbors", which is a lot for a small problem.

Version B: what it wrote

ANSWER, 5.2 SECONDS

Hi [NEIGHBOR], I hope you're well! I've noticed the dog often barks after 10 PM, and I wanted to chat briefly to see if we can find a solution. I value our friendly relationship and appreciate your understanding. Let me know a good time to talk!

Thanks,

[MY NAME]

What it got right

- 49 words, under the 60 I asked for. I counted.
- Sticks to the facts: the dog, after 10 PM. No landlord, no rules.
- [NEIGHBOR] and [MY NAME] are left for you to fill in.
- Friendly, and it ends by asking to talk.

What needed fixing

- It says "often" where I said "most evenings". Small, but it changes the claim. Fix it before sending.
- "I value our friendly relationship" is generic. Say it your own way.

EXAMPLE 2

Explaining a heat pump

A contractor mentioned a heat pump and you want to understand it. You are not an engineer.

The point: naming the reader (a 10-year-old) and the length (5 sentences) made it plain. Still check each rule, because it can break one quietly.

VERSION A: THE SHORT ASK

Explain how a heat pump works.

VERSION B: THE SPECIFIC ASK

Explain how a heat pump works to a 10-year-old in exactly 5 sentences. Use one everyday comparison. Do not use the words refrigerant, compressor or thermodynamic. Plain text.

Version A: what it wrote

EXCERPT OF THE ANSWER, 29.2 SECONDS

Only parts of the answer are shown here, with [...] where I skipped text. The full answer is in the appendix at the end.

A heat pump is a device that efficiently transfers heat from one location to another, providing both heating and cooling for residential or commercial spaces. It operates on the principles of thermodynamics, using a refrigeration cycle to move heat against its natural gradient. Here's a detailed breakdown:

[...]

Compressor: Pressurizes the refrigerant, raising its temperature.

[...]

Condenser: Releases heat as the refrigerant condenses from gas to liquid.

[...]

Efficiency (COP): The Coefficient of Performance (COP) measures efficiency. For example, a COP of 3 means the pump delivers 3 units of heat for every 1 unit of electricity consumed, making it far more efficient than resistive heating.

[...]

Types of Heat Pumps

[...]

Air-Source: Transfers heat between the building and outdoor air (most common).

What needed fixing

- About 395 words, with a parts list, a "COP" explanation and three types of pumps. I did not ask for a manual.
- It uses refrigerant, compressor, condenser and expansion valve with no plain explanation. Fine for a student, hard for a first read.
- Its numbers (COP of 3) are an example. I did not check them against a source, and I make no claim about any real heat pump.

Version B: what it wrote

ANSWER, 20.2 SECONDS

A heat pump is like a magical bus that moves warmth instead of people. In winter, it picks up heat from the air, ground, or water outside—even if it feels cold—and carries it inside your home to keep you warm. In summer, it flips directions, taking hot air from inside and dropping it outside to cool your house. It uses energy to shuffle warmth back and forth, like a delivery truck that never creates new packages but just moves them around. This smart system keeps your home cozy in winter and fresh in summer without burning fuel!

What it got right

- Exactly 5 sentences. I counted five endings.
- None of the three banned words appear. I checked the text.
- Plain and short at 97 words. Heat is "moved", not "made".

What needed fixing

- I asked for one everyday comparison. It gave two: a bus and a delivery truck. I missed this on the first read.
- "Magical bus" is cute but mixes ideas. A reader may think the bus is the answer. Treat it as a sketch, not a lesson.
- It left out how much energy it uses, which I did not ask about.

EXAMPLE 3

Choosing a laptop

You need a laptop for school and streaming.
The budget is 600 dollars.

The point: if you do not want guesses, say so. Then use its questions to think about what you really need.

VERSION A: THE SHORT ASK

Help me choose a laptop.

VERSION B: THE SPECIFIC ASK

I need a laptop for school and streaming video. My budget is 600 dollars. Do not name specific models or prices, because they change. Instead, ask me 5 short questions that would help me decide, then say in one line what each answer would change. Plain text. Write money as N dollars.

Version A: what it wrote

EXCERPT OF THE ANSWER, 23.3 SECONDS

Only parts of the answer are shown here, with [...] where I skipped text. The full answer is in the appendix at the end.

To help you choose the best laptop, I'll need a few details to narrow things down. Let's start with some key questions:

[...]

- Acer Swift 3 (AMD Ryzen 5/Intel i5, lightweight, ~\$600–\$800).

[...]

- Chromebook (Acer Chromebook Spin 713, budget-friendly at \$400–\$600).

[...]

Let me know your answers to the questions above, and I'll refine the suggestions! [smiley emoji]

What needed fixing

- It asks questions, then names models with prices like "about \$600-\$800". I did not check any of these. Models and prices change.
- The raw answer had formatting symbols ("###", "**") showing as text in the middle of lines. I cleaned them in the appendix. In the chat they were not rendered as formatting.
- I gave no clear need, so it asks. Good. But it also pushes a list of products.

Version B: what it wrote

ANSWER, 24.4 SECONDS

Do you need the laptop to be lightweight for carrying between classes?

Changes focus to portability vs. performance trade-offs.

How many hours of continuous use do you expect from the battery?

Determines emphasis on battery life and power efficiency.

Will you store most files locally or rely on cloud storage?

Affects storage capacity needs and SSD/HDD prioritization.

What screen size do you prefer (e.g., 13", 15.6", 17")?

Balances display quality for streaming against portability.

Do you want the ability to upgrade components like RAM or storage later?

Influences whether to prioritize upgradability or fixed high-end specs.

What it got right

- No model names and no prices, as I asked.
- Five short questions, each with a one-line effect.
- The questions are practical: carrying, battery, storage, screen size and upgrades.

What needed fixing

- It does not ask the one thing you would most want settled: whether you need Windows, Mac or Chromebook. You have to add that.
- Question 4 mixes screen size with streaming and portability. Read it twice.
- I did not test any laptop. This is not shopping advice.

What I took from this

The specific version won every time. It was shorter, closer to the facts and easier to use. It still broke one rule (the second comparison) and shifted a meaning slightly. A better prompt helps, but you still have to check the result.

Before you send a short ask, add:

1. What is true.
2. What not to mention.
3. A length, as a number.
4. A format: note, list, 5 sentences.
5. Placeholders for names.

Then count and read the result. Did it follow every rule?

The prompts

Copy these and change them.

PROMPT 1A

Write a note to my neighbor about noise.

PROMPT 1B

Write a note to my neighbor. Facts: their dog barks most evenings after 10 pm. I like them and want to keep things friendly. I want to ask if we can talk about it. Do not mention the landlord or any rules. Under 60 words. Plain text. Leave [NEIGHBOR] and [MY NAME] as placeholders.

PROMPT 2A

Explain how a heat pump works.

PROMPT 2B

Explain how a heat pump works to a 10-year-old in exactly 5 sentences. Use one everyday comparison. Do not use the words refrigerant, compressor or thermodynamic. Plain text.

PROMPT 3A

Help me choose a laptop.

PROMPT 3B

I need a laptop for school and streaming video. My budget is 600 dollars. Do not name specific models or prices, because they change. Instead, ask me 5 short questions that would help me decide, then say in one line what each answer would change. Plain text. Write money as N dollars.

Appendix: the full Version A answers

Optional reading. These are the complete answers to the short asks. I cleaned the formatting only: stray symbols such as ### and ** are removed, and list items are put on separate lines. The words are unchanged. Two emoji that a PDF cannot show are written as [star emoji] and [smiley emoji].

ANSWER 1A (237 WORDS)

Dear Neighbor,

Hi there! I hope you're doing well and enjoying our neighborhood as much as I do. I really appreciate having you around and always try to be considerate of others, but I wanted to kindly bring something up in the spirit of mutual respect.

There have been a few recent occasions—especially late in the evening or early in the morning—when the noise level (music, TV, or conversations) seemed a bit louder than usual. I've had trouble catching sleep during those times, and I wanted to ask if you'd be willing to help keep things a bit quieter during those hours. I totally understand that life happens, and sometimes things get lively, but even a small adjustment would make a big difference!

If you ever have guests over or need to do something noisy, maybe we could chat beforehand to find a solution that works for both of us? I'm happy to

discuss it further if needed.

Thanks so much for being understanding—this is such a great community, and I'm confident we can figure this out together. Looking forward to continuing to be friendly neighbors!

Best regards,

[Your Name]

[Your Address, if needed]

P.S. Sorry for any awkwardness—I hate to bring it up, but I truly appreciate your thoughtfulness!

This note balances politeness with clarity, frames the request as a collaborative effort, and avoids blame to maintain a positive relationship. Adjust details as needed! [star emoji]

ANSWER 2A (395 WORDS)

A heat pump is a device that efficiently transfers heat from one location to another, providing both heating and cooling for residential or commercial spaces. It operates on the principles of thermodynamics, using a refrigeration cycle to move heat against its natural gradient. Here's a detailed breakdown:

Core Components

Compressor: Pressurizes the refrigerant, raising its temperature.

Condenser: Releases heat as the refrigerant condenses from gas to liquid.

Expansion Valve: Reduces the refrigerant's pressure, cooling it rapidly.

Evaporator: Absorbs heat as the refrigerant evaporates from liquid to gas.

Reversing Valve: Switches the refrigerant flow direction for heating/cooling modes.

How It Works

1. Heating Mode

Evaporation: Cold refrigerant absorbs outdoor heat (even in cold weather) in the evaporator, turning into a low-pressure gas.

Compression: The compressor pressurizes the gas, significantly increasing its temperature.

Condensation: The hot, high-pressure gas flows to the condenser (indoors), releasing heat into the building as it condenses into a liquid.

Expansion: The liquid refrigerant passes through the expansion valve, dropping in pressure and temperature, restarting the cycle.

2. Cooling Mode

The reversing valve flips the refrigerant flow:

Evaporation: The refrigerant evaporates indoors, absorbing heat from inside the building.

Compression & Condensation: The hot gas releases heat outdoors via the condenser.

Expansion: The refrigerant cools and cycles back indoors.

Key Principles

Heat Transfer: Heat pumps don't generate heat but move existing heat. Even in cold weather, outdoor air retains enough thermal energy for extraction.

Laws of Thermodynamics: Heat naturally flows from hot to cold, but the heat pump uses electrical energy (via the compressor) to reverse this flow.

Efficiency (COP): The Coefficient of Performance (COP) measures efficiency. For example, a COP of 3 means the pump delivers 3 units of heat for every 1 unit of electricity consumed, making it far more efficient than resistive heating.

Types of Heat Pumps

Air-Source: Transfers heat between the building and outdoor air (most common).

Ground-Source (Geothermal): Uses the stable underground temperature for heat exchange, offering higher efficiency.

Water-Source: Relies on a water body (e.g., a pond) for heat transfer.

Advantages

Energy Efficiency: Uses less electricity compared to fossil fuel-based heating.

Versatility: Provides both heating and cooling.

Environmental Impact: Reduces greenhouse gas emissions by relying on electricity (especially with renewable sources).

In essence, a heat pump is a reversible, highly efficient system that leverages the refrigeration cycle to maintain comfort by strategically moving heat, rather than generating it.

ANSWER 3A (305 WORDS)

To help you choose the best laptop, I'll need a few details to narrow things down. Let's start with some key questions:

1. Budget

What's your price range? (e.g., \$500–\$1,000, \$1,500+, or flexible?)

2. Primary Use

- Basic tasks: Web browsing, email, office work (Word, spreadsheets).
- Creative work: Video editing, graphic design, music production.
- Gaming: AAA titles, casual gaming, or none?
- Programming/development: Heavy multitasking, virtual machines, etc.
- Portability: Will you carry it often (e.g., student, traveler)?

3. Operating System Preference

- Windows, macOS, Chrome OS, or Linux?

4. Hardware Priorities

- Screen size: 13", 15", or larger (e.g., 17")?
- Battery life: Need 8+ hours of unplugged use?

- Performance: Do you need a focus on CPU, GPU, RAM, or storage (SSD vs HDD)?
- Features: Touchscreen, 2-in-1 convertible, stylus support, backlit keyboard?

5. Brands or Preferences

- Any brands you trust (e.g., Apple, Dell, HP, Lenovo, ASUS)?

General Recommendations Based on Use Cases:

Budget-Friendly Everyday Use

- Acer Swift 3 (AMD Ryzen 5/Intel i5, lightweight, ~\$600–\$800).
- Lenovo IdeaPad Slim 7 (Great value for basic tasks).

Power Users (Creative Work/Gaming)

- MacBook Pro 16" (M2/M3 chip, stunning display, pricier).
- ASUS ROG Zephyrus (Slim gaming laptop with RTX graphics).
- Dell XPS 15 (High-end specs, premium design).

Portability & Battery Life

- MacBook Air M2/M3 (Lightweight, all-day battery).
- HP Spectre x360 (Convertible touchscreen, sleek design).

Student or Casual Use

- Chromebook (Acer Chromebook Spin 713, budget-friendly at \$400–\$600).
- Lenovo Yoga 7i (Versatile 2-in-1, mid-range price).

Key Specs to Prioritize:

Processor: Intel i5/i7, AMD Ryzen 5/7, or Apple M2/M3.

RAM: 8GB (minimum), 16GB+ for multitasking.

Storage: 256GB SSD (minimum), 512GB+ for large files.

GPU: Integrated (basic use) vs. dedicated (RTX 3050+ for gaming/creative work).

Let me know your answers to the questions above, and I'll refine the suggestions! [smiley emoji]

Limits and sources

- One public demo model, one day, one run per prompt. Another run or tool can answer differently, including wrongly.
- I counted words and sentences with a script and read the results myself. I did not check any heat pump or laptop facts.
- This is not shopping, home or relationship advice.
- The neighbor and the laptop shopper are made up.

TOOL

Qwen3 demo:

huggingface.co/spaces/Qwen/Qwen3-Demo

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